

Carry On, Mr. Bowditch

Chapter 11



CHAPTER 11



WHAT NEXT?

On Tuesday of Nat's last week at the chandlery Ben Meeker drifted in and leaned against a barrel. "Well, Nat, it's almost over — seems like — eh?"

"What do you mean — *seems like*?" Nat asked him.

"I told you nine years ago you were becalmed, didn't I? And you are. Your indenture's almost over — but what can you do? Keep on working in a chandlery, like as not." Ben shook his head. "And if things keep going from bad to worse, you won't have this job very long. Our merchant ships will be wiped off the seas."

Nat snorted. "Bosh!" But he knew there was something in what Ben said. American ships were having a hard time. Ever since America had won her freedom from England, she had to fight for her rights on the high seas. Now England and France were at war, and things were in a worse fix than ever. President Washington was trying to keep America at peace with both countries. He had declared his country's neutrality — had said America would not side with either country. Now both England and France were attacking American ships. Yes, there was something in what Ben said.

Ben sighed and shook his head again. "We ought to have sided with France back in '89 when their revolution started. If we had, we wouldn't be having trouble with France now. They'd be helping us against England."

Nat said, "Humph! The French people killed their king. Now they've got Napoleon. He doesn't sound much better than a king to me."

"We should have sided with France," Ben repeated. He pulled a dirty scrap of paper from his pocket. "I got a piece here that I cut out of a newspaper. The editor put it just right. He gives Washington a good going-over for not siding with France." He unfolded the paper. "Listen to this!"

“No! I don’t want to hear it!” Nat said. “And I don’t think editors have any right to talk against the President. Americans ought to stand together!”

Behind Nat someone chuckled. Nat turned. Dr. Bentley was looking at him with a twinkle. “Is this a political argument?”

Nat shrugged. “No argument at all. Ben’s got an article there that talks against the President. I said I didn’t want to hear it. I said that sort of thing ought to be stopped.”

To Nat's amazement, Dr. Bentley shook his head. "No, Nat. We can't have freedom — unless we have freedom."

Nat stiffened. "Does that mean the right to tell lies?"

Dr. Bentley smiled. "It means the right to have our own opinions. Human problems aren't like mathematics, Nat. Every problem doesn't have just one answer; sometimes you get several answers — and you don't know which is the right one."

Nat felt his face get hot. "But people don't have a right to talk against the President, do they? That's going too far!"

"Years ago," Dr. Bentley said, "before we won our independence, the *Essex Almanac* published something about freedom of the press. It was true then; it's just as true now. I may not have the exact words, but it went something like this:

"The Press is dangerous in a despotic government, but in a free country it is very useful, *so long as it is free*; for it is very important that people should be told everything that concerns them. If we argue against any branch of liberty, just because sometimes people abuse that liberty, then we argue against liberty itself. *In a free country, the press must be free.*"

Ben waved his dirty scrap of paper. "See? Dr. Bentley agrees with this! See?"

Dr. Bentley shook his head. "No. I just agree with a man's right to say what he thinks."

Ben mumbled something and shuffled out of the chandlery.

"Well, Nat?" Dr. Bentley said.

"I never thought of it that way," Nat admitted, "but I guess that's the way it has to be; 'we can't have freedom unless we have freedom.' And that means freedom to speak our minds."

Dr. Bentley nodded soberly. "Remember that, always." Then his eyes twinkled. "Why did Ben come around this morning? To shake his head over your prospects?"

Nat grinned. "That was about it. Ben certainly enjoys groaning about hard times, doesn't he?"

"Well, Nat, I don't know what next year or the year after holds for you. But I've an offer for you right now. Captain Gibaut and I are going to do a survey of Salem. There's a place for you on our crew. It's nothing permanent — but it's a job for a few months — if you'd like."

"I'd like that fine — and thank you for thinking of me."

"I'm doing us a favor," Dr. Bentley told him. "We can use your knack with figures."

That evening Nat went over to tell Mary the news.

Mary smiled, then sighed. "I'm glad you're not going to sea, Nat. We have enough men at sea. I wonder where they all are tonight — Hab and William and Sammy — and David?"

"They're all right, Mary."

"You don't know what it's like for a woman, Nat," Mary went on. "You say good-by to your man. His ship stands out from Salem Harbor. Then the months pass — sometimes the years — with no word from him."

“They’ll be coming back; just wait and see.”

“I do wait,” Mary told him. “I spend most of my life waiting.”

Nat could not think of an answer to that.

It was less than a month later that Sammy’s ship returned from Jamaica — without Sammy. He had died of fever in the West Indies.

Nat took the word to Mary.

She stared at him with stricken eyes. "I wonder who'll be next?"

Again Nat could think of no answer. He wished he could tell her that all the others were safe. But he wasn't so sure. Every day, as he worked on the survey of Salem, he heard more stories of trouble at sea. It seemed that every ship that returned brought bad news.

Captain Ware came home, raging because the English had searched his ship and had taken two of his men. "Swore they'd deserted from the English navy! Humph! Neither lad had been off soundings till he sailed with me."

Captain Reed came home, grim-faced. He'd had a running fight with a French privateer and had lost three men. "Shot down in cold blood, they were! What's Congress going to do to protect our shipping? Just sit there in Philadelphia and talk about it?"

Someone said John Jay was in England, trying to iron out our problems with the British.

Captain Gibaut snorted at that. "Bah! Diplomats can't settle this! We need a navy! I'm lucky to be surveying Salem instead of walking a quarter-deck!"

In November, John Jay returned, bringing the treaty he had worked out with England. Captain Gibaut roared at the terms of the treaty. "You call that a 'matter-of-give-and-take'? Bah! We give and England takes! And not a word about that business of the British searching our ships and seizing our men! That Jay treaty hasn't settled anything! As long as England thinks she rules the seas, we're going to have trouble with her! If I had the sense of a cabin boy, I'd never go to sea again!"

Two days later, Gibaut had signed on to command a

Derby ship, as soon as the survey was finished. He was to take the *Henry* on a voyage around the Cape of Good Hope to the Isle of Bourbon, off the east coast of Africa.

One day he said, "Nat, have you ever thought of going to sea?"

Nat remembered all the brawny swaggering seamen who had crowded the chandlery. He thought of stories of captains who could knock a man from starboard rail to larboard scuppers with one blow of a fist. "I'm five-feet-five when I stretch," he said. "Do you think I have the build for a life at sea?"

Gibaut chuckled. "You wouldn't throw much weight on a halyard — that's one thing sure. But you'd do all right as ship's clerk. You might work up to supercargo."

"What's the difference," Nat asked, "between clerk and supercargo?"

Gibaut shrugged. "The pay, mostly. They both do the figuring. It's an easy job — if you have a head for figures. In port, there's plenty to do. We may sell one cargo, buy another, sell that in the next port, and buy a third. But between ports, you'd have an easy time. No watches to stand, no decks to swab."

"I wonder," Nat said, "if a captain would let me take my notebooks on board and study between ports?"

Gibaut stared. "Are you still studying? What else do you want to know? Dr. Bentley says you already know more mathematics than any man in the country!" He shrugged. "But, if you still want to study, you could bring your notebooks along for all of me!"

Nat's heart jumped. Was Gibaut talking about his going on the *Henry*? In a Derby ship? Nat's scalp tingled, just thinking about the Derby ships: the *Quero*, that took

the news of Lexington to London; the *Astrea*, that brought the news of the peace from Paris; the *Lighthouse* — first ship to carry the stars and stripes to the Baltic; the *Grand Turk* — first New England ship in the Orient.

He looked at Gibaut. "You — you're talking about my sailing with you?"

Gibaut roared, "What in blazes did you think I was talking about?" He chuckled again. "That's it, Nat. A berth as clerk on the *Henry*. And you'll be allowed cargo space for a venture of your own — something you want to take along to sell."

"How much room could I have?" Nat asked.

Gibaut shrugged. "Any reasonable amount."

"When I finish my work on the survey," Nat said, "I'll have a hundred and thirty-five dollars. Could I invest that much in a venture, and have room for it?"

"A hundred and . . . " Gibaut shouted with laughter. "Don't worry, Nat. There'll be plenty of room for your venture."

"I wonder," Nat said, "why they call it a *venture*?"

Gibaut was still chuckling. "Because it is a venture — a risk. Any cargo is a risk. When we get to Bourbon, we may find people begging for our cargo and we may sell everything for three times what we paid for it. Or maybe when we get there, they won't want anything we have. Maybe we'll find there have been eight or ten ships there just ahead of us. Then we'll lose our shirts. We never know."

"I wouldn't want to lose my whole hundred and thirty-five dollars. I wonder if there's anything I could be sure I'd sell?"

"You can't be sure of anything," Gibaut said. "But ask Monsieur Bonnefoy about it. He ought to know. He comes from Bourbon. Fact is, he's going home on the *Henry*."

The next day Nat questioned Monsieur Bonnefoy.

"A venture to Bourbon, monsieur?" Bonnefoy said. "Take something in the line of clothing. You see, Bourbon produces almost nothing but coffee and sugar. We've always depended on our mother country for everything. Since the beginning of the Revolution, though, France has been too busy with battles to keep up with our needs. Too much bloodshed — not enough boots and shoes."

"Boots and shoes?" Nat said. "I think I can get shoes reasonably . . ."

Soon he had invested almost all his money in boots, half boots, and shoes, and had ordered them to be packed for the journey to Bourbon.

He got out his notebook on navigation and studied it all over again. He borrowed a logbook from Captain Gibaut, and copied it — just to be sure he knew how a log was kept.

David Martin's ship anchored. He sympathized with Mary over Sammy's death, but he said, "Don't blame the sea, dear. Men die of yellow fever in the States, too. Remember how it was with Philadelphia in '93?" And his eyes lighted at the news that Nat was going to sea. He gave Nat a sextant. "You'll catch on to using it in no time," he said.

"I've tried them out — on land of course. I guess at sea . . . " Nat paused.

David chuckled. "First time you try to shoot the sun, it's about like trying to thread a needle when you're running downhill."

Nat told David about his venture, and the logbook he'd made. "The only thing I'm trying to decide is — which notebooks to take with me."

David smiled and shook his head. "Still studying? Take all of them, why don't you?"

"I wouldn't want anything to happen to them. I mean — if the *Henry* . . ."

David chuckled. "If the *Henry* sinks, where'll you be?"

Mary gasped. "*David!*"

"But what if I happened to be saved and the notebooks — " Nat asked. "I tell you, David, there's a lot of information in them."

David chuckled again. "Make a bargain with Gibaut — if anything happens to the *Henry*, you want to go down with your ship."

"*David Martin!*" Mary gasped, and then she smiled. "You!"

Nat smiled, too, and told them good night.

Back in his room, he took the sextant out of its case. He stood, feet apart, swaying with the imaginary movement of the deck, and lifted the sextant. Some day soon, on the *Henry* . . .

The next day he was down at the wharf, watching the loading of the *Henry*, when he saw Captain Gibaut striding toward him. Gibaut certainly seemed to be in a tearing hurry. Maybe they were sailing sooner than they had expected.

Nat hailed him. "Any news?"

For a moment Gibaut stared at Nat as though he didn't see him. Then he spoke through his teeth. "That Elias Hasket Derby! Of all the stubborn fools that ever

. . . I wouldn't command the *Henry* if he gave her to me!"

Nat gulped. "You — you — aren't commanding the *Henry*?"

"No!" Gibaut bellowed.

"But — but — do you know who is?"

"I don't know and I don't care!" And Gibaut strode toward the ship, bellowing directions to the men to bear a hand with his gear.

Dazed, Nat left the wharf. Still in a daze, he went to his room. Now what would he do?

All that long night, until the pale winter sun rose, Nat tossed and turned and hunted for an answer. What would he do with his venture? Almost every cent he had in the world was tied up in it. And now — Gibaut was not commanding the *Henry*!